

4.3 Turning information overload into digestible notes

Reading a long report or article but short on time? AI-powered summarisation is becoming mainstream in both browsers and dedicated tools.

Generic workflow:

1. Copy key sections of the document (or upload if your AI supports files).
2. Prompt:
"Summarise this in:
 - 5 key bullet points,
 - one 2-sentence executive summary, and
 - 3 potential risks or open questions I should watch for."
3. Optionally, ask:
"Create 5 flashcards (Q&A) I can use to remember the core ideas."

Now your "reading" becomes learning, not just passive scanning.

5. Beat procrastination with AI

You can't outsource willpower, but you can outsource structure and encouragement.

The 10-minute "anti-procrastination" session

When you're stuck doom-scrolling:

"Act as my productivity coach. I'm procrastinating on [task].

1. Ask me 3 questions to clarify why I'm stuck.
2. Help me break [task] into a 3-step, 20-minute mini-plan.
3. Give me a 2-line pep talk and tell me to start a 10-minute timer."

Answer the questions honestly. The AI might uncover you're overwhelmed, unclear, or afraid of doing it badly. Once you have a tiny plan, commit to just 10 minutes.

Live check-ins: reporting back to your AI

You can treat ChatGPT/Gemini like a "focus log".

Workflow: 1–2 hour focus sprint

1. Before starting:
"For the next 90 minutes I want to focus on [task].
Help me structure it into 3 x 25-minute focus blocks with 5-minute breaks.
After each block, I will come back and update you with what I did.
At the end, evaluate how it went and suggest how to improve my next focus sprint."
2. Work 25 minutes. Report back with 2 lines.
3. Repeat for the next two cycles.
At the end, AI can reflect:
 - "You got stuck in the second block answering chats. Next time, set Do Not Disturb."

- "You estimated 3 sub-tasks but only completed 1. Let's scope smaller next time."

This is lo-fi, but it leverages AI's infinite patience to keep you honest.



Reframing guilt into data

Instead of "I wasted the whole day", ask AI for a kinder, more data-driven perspective.

"Today I planned to do [X, Y, Z] but I only completed [X]. I spent a lot of time on [distractions].

1. Reframe this day in a non-judgmental way.
2. Suggest 3 concrete changes I can apply tomorrow to reduce distractions.
3. Turn those into a simple "Tomorrow's Guardrails' checklist."
You'll get something like:
 - Guardrails: turn off notifications during deep work, schedule social media slot 19:00–19:30, keep only one tab open during focus blocks.

Pin that checklist where you'll see it tomorrow.

7. Recommended tools and pairings

By now you've seen a pattern:

- **LLM (ChatGPT/Gemini/Perplexity)** → brain for planning, analysing, drafting
- **Calendar app** → home for time blocks
- **Task app** → home for recurring & one-off tasks
- **Notes app** → home for logs, meeting notes, reflections

A few pairing ideas:

- **Planning:**
 - Use ChatGPT for designing schedules → paste into Google Calendar/Outlook as recurring blocks.